

The Rebate-Ready Garden

A Rain Garden for Your Downspout

A shallow, planted basin that soaks up roof water, feeds pollinators, and is built to your local rebate program's rules.

20 × 5 FEET · 41 PLANTS · FULL SUN TO PART SHADE · WET AFTER STORMS, DRY BETWEEN

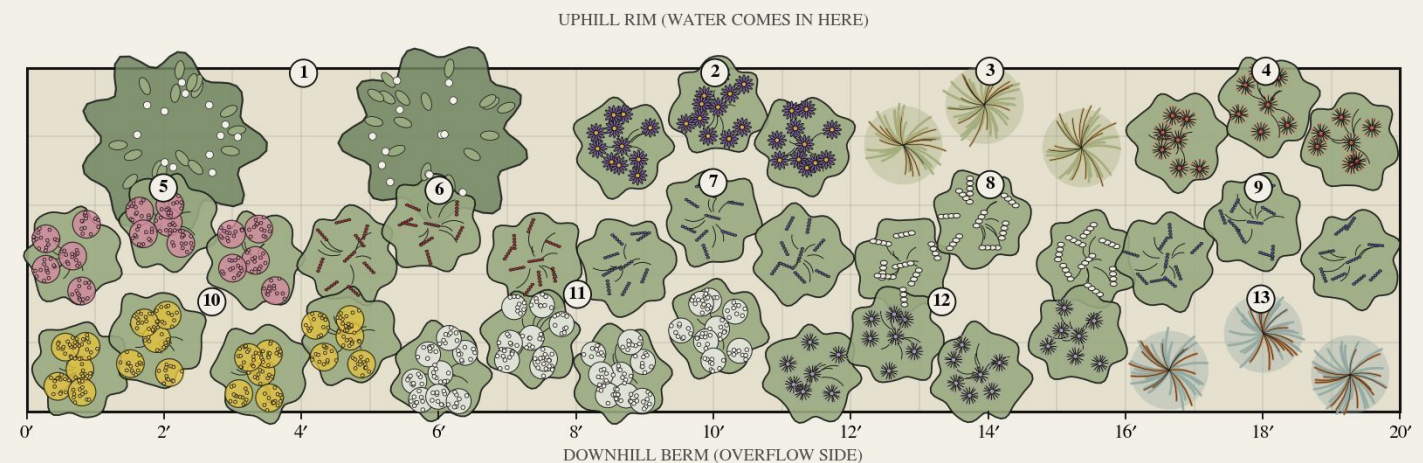


Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

A rain garden is a shallow bowl in the lawn, planted with flowers that don't mind wet feet. You run a downspout into it, and instead of sheeting off the driveway into the storm drain, the roof water sits for a day and sinks into the ground.

Every plant in this plan is native to New York. The middle of the bowl gets the plants that like it wettest: swamp milkweed, cardinal flower and blue vervain. The rim and the berm get tougher plants that can take a dry August.

Your local program may pay you back for building one. Page 4 shows what the program pays, what its rules are, and how this plan meets each one. Page 5 is the plant list and checklist, laid out the way the application asks for them.

Don't dig until your application is approved in writing, and call Miss Utility (811) first. After that it's a weekend of digging, a morning of planting, and a garden that waters itself.

WHAT TO BUY

- | | | |
|----------------------------|------------------------|------|
| ☐ 2 | Sweet pepperbush | (1) |
| ☐ 3 | New England aster | (2) |
| ☐ 3 | Switchgrass | (3) |
| ☐ 3 | Scarlet bee balm | (4) |
| ☐ 3 | Swamp milkweed | (5) |
| ☐ 3 | Cardinal flower | (6) |
| ☐ 3 | Blue vervain | (7) |
| ☐ 3 | White turtlehead | (8) |
| ☐ 3 | Great blue lobelia | (9) |
| ☐ 4 | Golden alexanders | (10) |
| ☐ 4 | Virginia mountain mint | (11) |
| ☐ 4 | Wild bergamot | (12) |
| ☐ 3 | Little bluestem | (13) |

41 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

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LONG ISLAND EDITION

HARDY IN ZONES 4-8 · PLAN NO. LI-13 · ORBITAL DESK LLC

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The Garden at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Sweet pepperbush

Clethra alnifolia · 3–8 ft · Jul–Aug

Late-summer bees and butterflies. Fragrant; coastal native that handles shade.

2. New England aster

Symphyotrichum novae-angliae · 3–6 ft · Aug–Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

3. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3–6 ft · Jul–Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

4. Scarlet bee balm

Monarda didyma · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Hummingbirds. Wants steady moisture; powdery mildew if too dry.

5. Swamp milkweed

Asclepias incarnata · 3–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Clump-forming milkweed that behaves well in garden beds.

6. Cardinal flower

Lobelia cardinalis · 2–4 ft · Jul–Sep

Hummingbirds. Needs consistently wet soil. Short-lived; let it self-sow.

7. Blue vervain

Verbena hastata · 2–5 ft · Jul–Sep

Bees; seeds feed birds. Tall candelabra spikes for wet meadows.

8. White turtlehead

Chelone glabra · 2–3 ft · Aug–Oct

Baltimore checkerspot caterpillar host. Bumblebees climb right inside the flowers.

9. Great blue lobelia

Lobelia siphilitica · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Bumblebees. Pairs well with cardinal flower.

10. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1–3 ft · May–Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

11. Virginia mountain mint

Pycnanthemum virginianum · 2–3 ft · Jul–Sep

One of the best plants for pollinator variety. Minty leaves; deer tend to leave it alone.

12. Wild bergamot

Monarda fistulosa · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Bumblebees and hummingbird moths. Tolerates drought once established.

13. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Sweet pepperbush → Black chokeberry

New England aster → Spotted Joe-Pye weed

Scarlet bee balm → Boneset

The Rebate-Ready Garden

What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Sweet pepperbush												
2. New England aster												
3. Switchgrass												
4. Scarlet bee balm												
5. Swamp milkweed												
6. Cardinal flower												
7. Blue vervain												
8. White turtlehead												
9. Great blue lobelia												
10. Golden alexanders												
11. Virginia mountain mint												
12. Wild bergamot												
13. Little bluestem												

The Almanac: Looking After It

BEFORE YOU DIG
Get written approval, call 811, and do the perc test. If water is still standing after 36 hours, pick another spot.

DIGGING
Dig the bowl to the depth on page 4, and pile the soil on the downhill side to make the berm. Keep the bottom level so the water spreads out.

PLANTING
Plant in spring or early fall. Set wet-lovers in the bottom, rim plants on the sides. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

MULCH
Spread shredded hardwood mulch 2-3 in deep between plants, not against stems. No landscape fabric.

THE FIRST YEAR
Weed every couple of weeks, and check the inlet after big storms. If soil washes in, set a few flat stones where the water enters.

KEEP IT WORKING
Leave the stems up over winter for the birds and bees, then cut them back in late April. The program expects you to keep the garden up, so keep your receipts and photos.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Your Rebate Packet

Nassau & Suffolk Counties, NY · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Reimburses plants and materials, at most \$500, if approved

Garden Rewards reimburses native plants, soil amendments, gravel and mulch with receipts; labor, tools, seed, shipping and tax don't count. North Hempstead reimburses native plants up to \$350. Cap: \$500 per property for Garden Rewards; \$350 in North Hempstead. Minimum size for this project: 20 sq ft. Programs covered: Long Island Garden Rewards (NEIWPCC), plus the Town of North Hempstead Native Plant Rebate. Who can apply: Nassau and Suffolk homeowners. North Hempstead residents use the town program; Peconic Estuary residents use the Peconic program.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	20 sq ft (North Hempstead: 50 sq ft)	✓ 100 sq ft
Depth	A shallow bowl, typically 3–8 inches	✓ Dig 6 in below the rim
Placement	At least 10 ft from foundations	✓ Placement notes below
Plants	Only species on the Long Island native plant list	✓ Every species checked against the 2025 list
Quantities	North Hempstead: at least 3 of each herbaceous species	✓ 3 or more of each species
Proof	Receipts and photos (before, dig, downspout, finished)	✓ Photo checklist on page 5

SIZING WORKSHEET

There's no sizing rule for Garden Rewards. A good rule of thumb is a garden about 20% of the roof area that drains to it. This 100 sq ft garden suits about 500 sq ft of roof. Roof area _____ sq ft × 0.20 = _____ sq ft.

PLACEMENT

At least 10 ft from the house and downhill of it. Not over a septic system or cesspool. Call 811 before digging.

THE PERC TEST

1. Dig a hole about 1 ft wide and 2 ft deep where the garden will go. 2. Fill it with water and let it drain. 3. Fill it again and set a ruler in it. 4. If it drains within about a day, the spot works; if water stands for days, pick another spot. Long Island's sandy soils usually drain fast.

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Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Sweet pepperbush	<i>Clethra alnifolia</i>	3 gal	2	48 in	NY
2	New England aster	<i>Symphotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
3	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
4	Scarlet bee balm	<i>Monarda didyma</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
5	Swamp milkweed	<i>Asclepias incarnata</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
6	Cardinal flower	<i>Lobelia cardinalis</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
7	Blue vervain	<i>Verbena hastata</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
8	White turtlehead	<i>Chelone glabra</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
9	Great blue lobelia	<i>Lobelia siphilitica</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY
10	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	4	18 in	NY
11	Virginia mountain mint	<i>Pycnanthemum virginianum</i>	Quart	4	18 in	NY
12	Wild bergamot	<i>Monarda fistulosa</i>	Quart	4	18 in	NY
13	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	3	18 in	NY

41 plants · 20 × 5 ft = 100 sq ft · 100% native to New York (USDA PLANTS) and on the Long Island native list · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 0.8 cubic yards of shredded hardwood at 2.5 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Check which program you're in: Garden Rewards, North Hempstead, or Peconic Estuary.
- ☐ North Hempstead: apply BEFORE you buy, with the size, species list, layout, photos and budget. Garden Rewards: no pre-approval.
- ☐ Buy only listed native species (this plan's list qualifies). Keep every receipt and ask for itemized ones.
- ☐ Call 811 before digging.
- ☐ Build it and take the photos on this page.
- ☐ Submit the reimbursement form with receipts and photos (Garden Rewards fall round: by Oct 31 or until funds run out).
- ☐ Keep the garden up for at least 3 years; Garden Rewards expects it.

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The spot before you start
- ☐ The dug bowl (excavation)
- ☐ The downspout connection
- ☐ The finished garden with plants in the ground
- ☐ Each plant with its tag or labeled pot

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

Every itemized receipt (plants, soil amendments, mulch), your photos, any approval, and this packet.

SOURCES

neiwpcc.org Long Island Garden Rewards page (updated 9/1/26) and FAQ; NYFA Long Island Native Plants list (generated 4/1/25); Town of North Hempstead 2026 Native Plant Rebate terms.